

ser to the launch of statements.

SECTION: total-rewards/compensation/compensation-review-cycle/review-cycle-inputs.md

Notice: The below pertains to the recently completed FY26 Annual Compensation Review Cycle. Updated information for FY27 will be shared closer to the launch of the cycle.

Introduction

On this page, we explain how we review our Compensation Calculator in preparation for the Compensation Review Cycle.

Reviews Conducted for Annual Compensation Review

Benchmarking Review

Benchmarking review is an internal process completed by the Compensation team to determine any adjustments to role benchmarks.

Process

1. All roles are reviewed using market data from Radford and Comptryx.
1. The benchmark is increased based on the output of market data and internal alignment to peer roles.
1. Once the new benchmarks are reviewed and approved, these are updated in the compensation calculator.

Location Factor Review

The location factor review is an internal process completed by the Compensation team to determine any adjustments to location factors for the next FY which is completed in November.

Process

1. All localities where we have team members and/or are actively recruited are reviewed using data from Radford, Comptryx, and ERI.
1. Location factors are increased only if there is an increase as compared to SF of at least 5%.
1. Once the new location factors are reviewed and approved, these are updated in the compensation calculator.

Note: Please note that a change in location factor or benchmark does not imply a change in compensation. Team members will be reviewed for a market adjustment if they are below the minimum of the range.

SECTION: values/_index.md

CREDIT

GitLab's six core values are

- Collaboration,
- Results for Customers,
- Efficiency,
- Diversity, Inclusion & Belonging,
- Iteration, and

■■ Transparency,

and together they spell the CREDIT we give each other by assuming good intent. We react to them with values emoji and they are made actionable below.

About our values

We take inspiration from other companies, and we always go for the boring solutions. Our co-founder, Sid Sijbrandij, has shared the origin of each of the CREDIT values, but

just like the rest of our work, we continually adjust our values and strive to make them better.

GitLab values are a living document.

In many instances, they have been documented, refined, and revised based on lessons learned (and scars earned) in the course of doing business.

We used to have more values, but it was difficult to remember them all. In response, we condensed them, created an acronym (CREDIT), and listed operating principles to guide behavior.

Everyone is welcome to suggest improvements. Please assign MRs to update these values to our Chief People Officer and if you work at GitLab, also @mention them in the values Slack channel.

Driving Results with CREDIT from GitLab on Vimeo.

■ Collaboration{collaboration}

To achieve results, team members must work together effectively. At GitLab, helping others is a priority, even when it is not immediately related to the goals that you are trying to achieve.

Similarly, you can rely on others for help and advice—in fact, you're expected to do so.

Anyone can chime in on any subject, including people who don't work at GitLab.

The person who's responsible for the work decides how to do it,

but they should always take each suggestion seriously and try to respond and explain why it may or may not have been implemented.

Kindness

We value caring for others.

Demonstrating we care for people provides an effective framework for challenging directly and delivering feedback.

Kindness doesn't mean holding back on feedback or avoiding disagreements, these are crucial to professional growth and getting results for customers.

Kindness means you make a separation between the work and the person, you can criticize someone's work but still be respectful to the person.

Give as much positive feedback as you can, and do it in a public way.

Share

There are aspects of GitLab culture, such as intentional transparency, that are unintuitive to outsiders and new team members.

Be willing to invest in people and engage in open dialogue.

For example, consider making private issues public wherever possible so that we can all learn from the experience. Don't be afraid of judgement or scrutiny when sharing publicly, we all understand it's

impossible to know everything.

Everyone can remind anyone in the company about our values.

If there is a disagreement about the interpretations, the discussion can be escalated to more people within the company without repercussions.

Share problems you run into, ask for help, be forthcoming with information and speak up.

Negative feedback is 1-1

Give negative feedback in the smallest setting possible.

One-on-one video calls are preferred.

Negative feedback is distinct from negativity and disagreement. If there is no direct feedback involved, strive to discuss disagreement in a public channel, respectfully and transparently.

In a GitLab Unfiltered interview on values, GitLab co-founder Sid Sijbrandij offers the following context.

> We deal with negative all the time at GitLab. If it's not a problem, then why are we discussing it? We deal with negativity a lot, and that's also part of our ambition.

>

> If you want to get better, you talk about what you can improve. We're allowed to publicly discuss negative things; we're not allowed to give negative feedback in a large setting if it could be feasibly administered in a smaller setting.

Negative feedback can be given in a group setting if it's to someone higher in the management chain. This shows that no one is above feedback.

Provide feedback in a timely manner

We want to solve problems while they are small.

If you are unhappy with anything (your duties, your colleague, your boss, your salary, your location, your computer), please voice your concerns rather than keeping them to yourself. If you need to escalate beyond your manager, you could consider speaking to your skip-level, a more senior person, or a people business partner.

Say thanks

Recognize the people that helped you publicly, for example in our thanks chat channel.

When publicly thanking, it's important to recognize the following:

- Showing thanks in as large a setting as possible (company-wide) at a company as large as ours is the exception instead of the norm, it takes some getting used to.
- Being thanked at the company level for what you view as a relatively small or minuscule contribution can feel awkward.
- Thanking a person in thanks should be done sincerely and summarize why you are thankful so the person on the receiving end can easily understand why they are being thanked. Even while assuming positive intent, not all folks are comfortable with public praise. Help this person understand how they went above and beyond and why you felt it was important for the team member to be recognized.
- There are a number of good ways and places to say thanks. We shouldn't limit saying thanks to just the thanks channel.

Give feedback effectively

Giving feedback is challenging, but it's important to deliver it effectively.

When providing feedback, always make it about the work itself;

focus on the business impact and not the person.

Make sure to provide at least one clear and recent example.

If a person is going through a hard time in their personal life, then take that into account.

An example of giving positive feedback is our thanks chat channel.

For managers, it's important to realize that team members react to a negative incident with their managers six times more strongly than they do to a positive one.

Keeping that in mind, if an error is so inconsequential that the value gained from providing criticism is low, it might make sense to keep that feedback to yourself.

In the situations where negative feedback must be given, focus on the purpose for that feedback: to improve the team member's performance going forward.

Give recognition generously, in the open, and often to generate more engagement from your team.

Get to know each other

We use a lot of text-based communication, and if you know the person behind the text, it will be easier to prevent conflicts.

So we encourage people to get to know each other on a personal level through informal communication, for example, virtual coffee chats, and during GitLab Summit.

Reach across company departments

While it's wise to seek advice from experts within your function, we encourage GitLab team members to do the same across departments. This enables the company to iterate more quickly, embrace the understanding that everyone can contribute and include more diverse perspectives when possible.

Don't pull rank

If you have to remind someone of the position you have in the company, you're doing something wrong.

People already know our decision-making process.

Explain why you're making the decision, and respect everyone irrespective of their function.

This includes using the rank of another person - including the CEO - to sell an idea or decision.

Assume positive intent

We naturally have a double standard when it comes to the actions of others.

We blame circumstances for our own mistakes, but individuals for theirs.

This double standard is called the Fundamental Attribution Error.

In order to mitigate this bias, you should always assume positive intent in your interactions with others, respecting their expertise and giving them grace in the face of what you might perceive as mistakes.

When disagreeing, folks sometimes argue against the weakest points of an argument, or an imaginary argument (e.g. "straw man"). Assume the points are presented in good faith, and instead try to argue against the strongest version of your opponent's position. We call this arguing against a "steel" position, instead of a "straw" one. This concept is borrowed from argue the "steel man" technique.

A "steel" position should be against the absolute most effective version of your opponent's position — potentially even more compelling than the one they presented. A good "steel" position is one where the other person feels you've represented their position well, even if they still disagree with your assumptions or conclusion.

Address behavior, but don't label people

There is a lot of good in this article about not wanting jerks on our team, but we believe that jerk is a label for behavior rather than an inherent classification of a person. We avoid classifications.

Say sorry

If you made a mistake, apologize as soon as possible.

Saying sorry is not a sign of weakness but one of strength.

The people that do the most work will likely make the most mistakes.

Additionally, when we share our mistakes and bring attention to them, others can learn from us, and the same mistake is less likely to be repeated by someone else.

Mistakes can include when you have not been kind to someone. In order to reinforce our values, it is important, and takes more courage, to apologize publicly when you have been unkind publicly (e.g., when you have said something unkind or unprofessional to an individual or group in a Slack channel).

No ego

Don't defend a point to win an argument or double-down on a mistake.

You are not your work; you don't have to defend your point.

You do have to search for the right answer with help from others.

In a GitLab Unfiltered interview, GitLab Head of Remote Darren M. adds context on this operating principle.

> In many organizations, there's a subtle, low-level, persistent pressure to continually prove your worth.

> And I believe that this fuels imposter syndrome and wreaks havoc on mental health.

>

> What's so troubling to me is how often perception is reality.

> In other words, those who have mastered the art of being perceived as elite reap benefits, though this has nothing to do with actual results.

>

> At GitLab, "no ego" means that we foster and support an environment where results matter, and you're given agency to approach your work in the way that makes sense to you.

> Instead of judging people for not approaching work in an agreed-upon way, "no ego" encourages people to glean inspiration from watching others approach work in new and different ways.

See others succeed

A candidate who has talked to a lot of people inside GitLab said that, compared to other companies, one thing stood out the most: everyone here mentioned wanting to see each other succeed.

Don't let each other fail

Keep an eye out for others who may be struggling or stuck.

If you see someone who needs help, reach out and assist. This might involve offering to pair program or setting up a sync brainstorming session. The goal is to connect them with someone else who can provide expertise or assistance.

We are a team, so we succeed and shine together by supporting each other!

People are not their work

Always make suggestions about examples of work, not the person.

Say "You didn't respond to my feedback about the design" instead of "You never listen".

And, when receiving feedback, keep in mind that feedback is the best way to improve, and that others giving you feedback want to see you succeed.

Do it yourself

Our collaboration value is about helping each other when we have questions, need critique, or need help.

No need to brainstorm, wait for consensus, or do with two what you can do yourself. The Bolt Handbook refers to this as the Founder Mentality, where all team members should approach the problem as if they own the company.

Blameless problem solving

Investigate mistakes in a way that focuses on the situational aspects of a failure's mechanism and the decision-making process that led to the failure, rather than cast blame on a person or team.

We hold blameless root cause analyses and retrospectives for stakeholders to speak up without fear of punishment or retribution.

Short toes

People joining the company frequently say, "I don't want to step on anyone's toes."

At GitLab, we should be more accepting of people taking initiative in trying to improve things.

As companies grow, their speed of decision-making goes down since there are more people involved.

We should counteract that by having short toes and feeling comfortable letting others contribute to our domain.

For example, pointed, respectful feedback to a proposal by GitLab's CEO led to his own merge request being closed. However, it is not required to respond to comments.

It's impossible to know everything

We know we must rely on others for the expertise they have that we don't.

It's OK to admit you don't know something and to ask for help, even if doing so makes you feel vulnerable.

It is never too late to ask a question, and by doing so, you can get the information you need to produce results and to strengthen your own skills as well as GitLab as a whole.

After your question is answered, please document the answer so that it can be shared.

Don't display surprise when people say they don't know something, as it is important that everyone feels comfortable saying "I don't know" and "I don't understand."

(As inspired by Recurse.)

Collaboration is not consensus

When collaborating, it is always important to stay above radar and work transparently, but collaboration is not consensus and disagreement is part of collaboration.

You don't need to ask people for their input, and they shouldn't ask you "Why didn't you ask me?".

You don't have to wait for people to provide input, if you did ask them.

You don't need to have everyone agreeing to the same thing - they can disagree, commit, and advocate. Two-way doors decisions can be reversed as part of disagree, commit, and advocate, while

one-way door decisions benefit from more input. Recognize these reversible two-way door decisions for when less input is required to iterate faster.

We believe in permissionless innovation — you don't need to involve people, but everyone can contribute.

This is core to how we iterate, since we want smaller teams moving quickly rather than large teams achieving consensus slowly.

Collaboration Competency

Competencies are the Single Source of Truth (SSoT) framework for things we need team members to learn.

We demonstrate collaboration when we take action to help others and include other's (both internal and external) input (both help and feedback) to achieve the best possible outcome.

GitLab Job Grade

Demonstrates Collaboration Competency by...

Knowledge Assessment

5

Develops collaboration skills by learning from other team members

Knowledge Assessment for Individual Contributors

6

Grows collaboration skills by using different types of communication; files issues appropriately, asks in the right Slack channels and uses the right labels.

7

Models collaborative behavior for fellow team members and others within the group.

8

Coaches team members on how to collaborate more effectively and pointing team members to the right channels to collaborate.

Knowledge Assessment for People Leaders

9

Fosters collaborative decision making and problem solving across the departments.

10

Drives team collaboration across divisions/departments, silos, and division boundaries.

11

Develops networks and builds partnerships, engages in cross-functional activities; collaborates across boundaries, and finds common ground with a widening range of stakeholders. Utilizes contacts to build and strengthen internal support base

12

Leads collaboration and teamwork in daily routines, prioritizing interactions, information sharing, and real time decision making across divisions/departments. Encourages greater cross-functional collaboration among e-team leaders.

14

Champions collaboration and teamwork into daily routines, prioritizing interactions, information sharing, and real time decision making across divisions/departments. Champions cross-functional collaboration among e-team leaders and GitLab.

■ Results for Customers {results}

We exist to help our customers achieve more. Everything we do should be in service of making our customers successful with GitLab. Results for Customers is at the top of our values hierarchy, as our customers achieving results drives overall business performance that enables everything else.

The Results for Customers value is displayed through the following operating principles:

Set Ambitious & Measurable goals

While we iterate with small changes, we strive for large, ambitious results. We have an ambitious mission and vision, and we aim to be the best in the world across all our functions. Setting ambitious, measurable goals enables us to best deliver customer results. We agree in writing on measurable goals. Within the company we use OKRs to stay accountable. We have and report against KPIs with guiding targets.

Understand our customers

All GitLab team members should understand our customers' needs, issues, and value propositions. We understand how they use GitLab and what they need from a platform in order to meet their goals. Internally facing teams consider the impact of their work as it pertains indirectly to GitLab's customers.

We better understand customers and their needs through:

- Reviewing public facing GitLab issues from our customers and users
- Dogfooding our product to understand the user experience
- Reading customer stories from Marketing and Sales
- Attending Customer fireside chats
- Learning feedback from our customers and users on product features and roadmap

Co-create

We create together with our customers. There is an open dialogue between GitLab and our customers so that we can better identify what they need. As a result of building a solution for them, we can also bring that solution to the world.

Keep end users in sight

Our focus is to increase customer results. At GitLab, one way to drive customer results is through platform enhancements that drive the most value for direct users. This requires being aware of the Concur effect.

Arvind Narayanan, a Princeton Professor, described his frustration with Blackboard in a viral Tweet:

>It has every feature ever dreamed up. But like anything designed by a committee, the interface is incoherent and any task requires at least fifteen clicks (and that's if you even remember the correct sequence the first time).

>

>Software companies can be breathtakingly clueless when there's a layer of indirection between them and their users. Everyone who's suffered through Blackboard will have the same reaction to this: try having less functionality!

Ryan Falor followed up on Narayanan's tweet with his definition of the Concur Effect:

- >1. decision makers are not direct users
- >1. features are overwhelming and disjointed
- >1. user experience gets worse over time

See the Hacker News discussion for a specific UX example.

At GitLab, we want to drive customer results through focusing on platform enhancements that drive the most value for direct users.

Customer results are more important than:

1. What we plan to make. If we focus only on our own plans, we would have only GitLab.com and no self-managed delivery of GitLab. This does not mean that we will agree to every feature request, but we won't let existing plans be an obstacle to working on what will drive the most customer value.
1. Large customer requests. Catering to requests from large customers leads to the innovator's dilemma, we need to also focus on results for small and future customers.
1. Our existing scope. For example, when customers asked for better integrations and complained about integration costs and effort, we responded by expanding our scope to create a single application for the DevOps lifecycle.
1. Our assumptions. Every company works differently, so we can't assume that what works well for us will support our customers' needs. When we have an idea, we must directly validate our assumptions with multiple customers to ensure we create scalable, highly relevant solutions.
1. What we control. We strive to provide the best possible experience for each of our customers, and take responsibility for all of the aspects that we can reasonably control.

Measure impact, not activity

We care about what you achieve: the code you shipped, the needle you moved, the user you made happy, and the team member you helped. Someone who took the afternoon off shouldn't feel like they did something wrong, unless it negatively impacted a goal or result they were responsible for. You don't have to defend how you spend your day if you are performing and delivering against expectations. We trust team members to do the right thing instead of having rigid rules. We trust team members to show up and do their best work. Do not incite competition by proclaiming how many hours you worked yesterday. If you are working too many hours, talk to your manager to discuss solutions.

Dogfooding

We use our own product in the way our users do to surface improvements that will lead to better customer results. GitLab is a DevSecOps Platform that can be used by people throughout the business. This is how we use it within GitLab. For example, we use our OKR functionality company-wide to inform product enhancements and for team members to have a great understanding of the customer experience. We also dogfood in the following ways:

1. Our development organization uses GitLab.com to manage the DevOps lifecycle of GitLab itself.
1. All team members use GitLab to collaborate on this handbook.
1. We capture content and processes in Git repos and manage them with GitLab.

When something breaks, doesn't work well, or needs improvement, we are more likely to notice it internally and address it before it impacts our larger community.

Give agency

We give people agency to focus on what they think is most beneficial. If a meeting doesn't seem interesting and someone's active participation is not critical to the outcome of the meeting, they can always opt to not attend, or during a video call they can work on other things if they want. Staying in the

call may still make sense even if you are working on other tasks, so other peers can ping you and get fast answers when needed. This is particularly useful in multi-purpose meetings where you may be involved for just a few minutes.

Challenger mindset

Challenging the status quo can lead to remarkable results - we must never stop. A challenger mindset requires that we continually ask ourselves bold, difficult questions about our business and the problems we solve, while resisting complacency. To succeed we must innovate and delight our customers with the value of the products we build. A challenger mindset requires a relentless pursuit of excellence - we must be tenacious. Each win for our customers builds reputational capital we can use to earn the trust of prospects in a competitive market. While competition is a feature of capitalism, internally as GitLab team members, we must focus our efforts inwardly on achieving our very best results for customers to win market share.

Growth mindset

You don't always get results and this will lead to criticism from yourself and/or others. We believe our talents can be developed through hard work, targeted training, learning from others, on-the-job experience, and receiving input from others. It is in our DNA as a company and individuals to look for opportunity, stay humble, and never settle. We try to hire people based on their trajectory, not their pedigree. We also strive to foster a culture of curiosity and continuous learning where team members are provided and proactively seek out opportunities to grow themselves and their careers. We believe that with the right expectations and direction, people can grow to take on new challenges and surpass expectations.

Cross-functional optimization

Our definition of cross-functional optimization is that you do what is best for the organization as a whole. Don't optimize for the goals of your team when it negatively impacts the goals of other teams, our users, and/or the company. Those goals are also your problem and your job. For example, you may have set a non-urgent functional milestone that is supposed to land at the end of the quarter. If delivering within the last week requires engagement from the GTM teams, the right decision may be to push your own team's target by a week to reduce the ask for the GTM team as the GTM focuses on meeting its revenue objectives.

In the context of collaboration, if anyone is blocked by you on a question, your approval, or a merge request review, you should prioritize unblocking them, either directly or through helping them find someone else who can.

Embrace Tenacity

We refer to this as "persistence of purpose". As talked about in The Influence Blog, tenacity is the ability to display commitment to what you believe in. You keep picking yourself up, dusting yourself off, and quickly get going again having learned a little more. We value the ability to maintain focus and motivation when work is tough and asking for help when needed.

Have Ownership & Accountability

We expect team members to complete tasks that they are assigned. You are responsible for executing with attention to detail, connecting the dots across the organization and anticipating and solving problems. As an owner, you are responsible for overcoming challenges, not suppliers or other team members. Take initiative and proactively inform stakeholders when there is something you might not be able to solve.

Sense of urgency

Time gained or lost has compounding effects. Try to get the results as fast as possible, but without compromising our other values and ways we communicate, so the compounding of results can begin

and we can focus on the next improvement.

Operate with a bias for action

It's important that we keep our focus on action, and don't fall into the trap of analysis paralysis or sticking to a slow, quiet path without risk. Decisions should be thoughtful, but delivering fast results requires the fearless acceptance of occasionally making mistakes; our bias for action also allows us to course correct quickly. Try to get results as fast as possible, but without compromising our other values and ways of working

Disagree, commit, and advocate {disagree-and-commit}

When a decision is in place, we expect people to commit to executing it. Any past decisions and guidelines are open to questioning as long as you act in accordance with them until they are changed. This is a common principle.

Every decision can be changed;

our best decision was one that changed an earlier one.

In a manager-report relationship, usually the report is the Directly Responsible Individual (DRI).

The manager may disagree with the final decision, but they still commit to the decision of the DRI.

In a group setting, participants may disagree with a proposal but not articulate their views for one reason or another. Sometimes, many or all individuals may disagree yet choose not to speak up, because no one believes they would get agreement from the group. As a result, everyone loses out on their feedback. Dissent is expression of that disagreement. However, it can be difficult and even socially expensive.

Expression of feedback is a way for everyone to grow and learn, and is based on facts rather than opinions. Share your perspective, rather than agreeing simply to avoid conflict or to go along with everyone else.

When you want to reopen the conversation on something, show that your argument is informed by previous conversations and assume the decision was made with the best intent.

You have to achieve results on every decision while it stands, even when you are trying to have it changed.

You should communicate with the DRI who can change the decision instead of someone who can't.

Escalate to unblock

If there is a disagreement and you can't move forward because of it, agree to escalate and escalate to one or both of your managers. Early escalation, delivered with context of the challenge, enables managers to function as an unblocker.

Results Competency

Competencies are the Single Source of Truth (SSoT) framework for things we need team members to learn.

We demonstrate results when we do what we promised to each other, customers, users, and investors.

GitLab Job Grade

Demonstrates Results Competency by...

Knowledge Assessment

5

Develops the skills needed to commit and execute on agreed actions.

Knowledge Assessment for Individual Contributors

6

Applies commitment to results and demonstrates ability to execute on agreed actions.

7

Models a sense of urgency and commitment to deliver results.

8

Coaches team members to collaborate and work iteratively towards impact with the focus on the outcome and not activity worked.

Knowledge Assessment for People Leaders

9

Fosters a culture of ownership of personal performance.

10

Drives efficient execution of results ensuring collaboration between team members.

11

Develops quarterly OKR's ensuring the performance and results of one or more teams.

12

Leads the achievement of results while driving the continued alignment to our values of collaboration, efficiency, diversity, iteration and transparency.

EVP/CXO

Leads the achievement of results while driving the continued alignment to our values of collaboration, efficiency, diversity, iteration and transparency.

■■ Efficiency {efficiency}

At GitLab, efficiency means producing results without wasting materials, time, or energy. We optimize solutions globally for the broader GitLab community over one person or a small group. Focus on efficiency should be global in nature, not just local to a given function. Global efficiency could include efficiency with customers, candidates, and contributors as well. It is easy to prioritize consistency over efficiency because consistency is often more efficient initially and makes managing processes more efficient. We should slow down when optimizing for consistency. Taking a company-wide lens when evaluating changes will help ensure that new processes will improve efficiency for GitLab as a whole and be the best decision for the company as a whole.

When we work internally with other team members, we leverage GitLab's unique working practices and operating principles to achieve top efficiency. We do not expect people outside of GitLab to conform to GitLab's ways of working, and we will make accommodations to work effectively with them. For example, we may collaborate heavily in-person and not default to async communications.

Only Healthy Constraints

Most companies regress to the mean and slow down over time. While some changes are required as a company grows and matures, not all change is inevitable or should be allowed to passively happen. As GitLab grows, we are conscious of how we operate and how it enables our ability to continue to operate with the agility of a startup. We try to limit ourselves to healthy constraints.

Write things down

We document everything: in the handbook, in meeting notes, in issues.

We do that because "the faintest pencil is better than the sharpest memory."

It is far more efficient to read a document at your convenience than to have to ask and explain. Having something in version control also lets everyone contribute suggestions to improve it.

Boring solutions

Use the simplest and most boring solution for a problem, and remember that "boring" should not be conflated with "bad" or "technical debt."

The speed of innovation for our organization and product is constrained by the total complexity we have added so far, so every little reduction in complexity helps.

Don't pick an interesting technology just to make your work more fun;

using established, popular tech will ensure a more stable and more familiar experience for you and other contributors.

Make a conscious effort to recognize the constraints of others within the team.

For example, sales is hard because you are dependent on another organization, and development is hard because you have to preserve the ability to quickly improve the product in the future.

Self-service and self-learning

Team members should first search for their own answers and, if an answer is not readily found or the answer is not clear, ask in public as we all should have a low level of shame. Write down any new information discovered and pay it forward so that those coming after will have better efficiency built on top of practicing collaboration, inclusion, and documenting the results.

Team members have more room to grow themselves when they are able to self-service and self-learn.

Efficiency for the right group

Optimize solutions globally for the broader GitLab community. As an example, it may be best to discard a renewal process that requires thousands of customers to each spend two hours in favor of one that only takes sixty seconds, even when it may make a monthly report less efficient internally! In a decision, ask yourself "For whom does this need to be most efficient?" Quite often, the answer may be your users, contributors, customers, or team members that are dependent upon your decision.

Be respectful of others' time

Consider the time investment you are asking others to make with meetings and a permission process. Try to avoid meetings, and if one is necessary, try to make attendance optional for as many people as possible. Any meeting should have an agenda linked from the invite, and you should document the outcome. Instead of having people ask permission, trust their judgment and offer a consultation process if they have questions.

Spend company money like it's your own

Every dollar we spend will have to be earned back. Be as frugal with company money as you are with your own. In saying this, we ask team members to weigh the cost of purchases against the value that they will bring to the company.

Consider the degree to which a purchase increases your ability to better accomplish your work and achieve business results relative to cost. Lowering overhead reduces the cost to operate the business and lets us shift spend toward other priority areas.

We have guidelines around this operating principle to help team members better understand our expensing process and expectations.

Frugality

Amazon states it best with: "Accomplish more with less. Constraints breed resourcefulness, self-sufficiency, and invention. There are no extra points for growing headcount, budget size, or fixed expense."

Short verbal answers

Give short answers to verbal questions so the other party has the opportunity to ask more or move on.

Keep broadcasts short

Keep one-to-many written communication short, as mentioned in this HBR study: "A majority say that what they read is frequently ineffective because it's too long, poorly organized, unclear, filled with jargon, and imprecise."

Managers of one

We want each team member to be a manager of one who doesn't need daily check-ins to achieve their goals. Team members are given the freedom to own projects and initiatives and are trusted to see them through to a successful end.

When team members are managers of one they can have an increased work/life balance, because they are more empowered to make decisions around how they allocate their time throughout each day.

Freedom and responsibility over rigidity

When possible, we give people the responsibility to make a decision and hold them accountable for that, instead of imposing rules and approval processes. You should have clear objectives and the freedom to work on them as you see fit. Freedom and responsibility are more efficient than rigidly following a process, or creating interdependencies, because they enable faster decision velocity and higher rates of iteration.

When team members have freedom and responsibility over rigidity, they have more room to help others.

Accept mistakes

Not every problem should lead to a new process to prevent them. Additional processes make all actions more inefficient; a mistake only affects one. Once you have accepted the mistake, learn from it. When team members are free to accept mistakes, they can take more calculated risks.

Move fast by shipping the minimal valuable change

We value constant improvement by iterating quickly, month after month. If a task is not the smallest viable and valuable thing, cut the scope.

Embrace change

Adoption of features, user requirements, and the competitive landscape change frequently and rapidly. The most successful companies adapt their roadmap and their organization quickly to keep pace. One of the things that makes this challenging is the impact on our team. People may need to change teams, subject matter, or even who manages them. This can rightly feel disruptive. If we coach ourselves to embrace the positive aspects of change, such as increased opportunity and new things to learn, we can move faster as a company and increase our odds of success. It is important to hold management accountable for being deliberate.

Efficiency Competency

Competencies are the Single Source of Truth (SSoT) framework for things we need team members to learn.

We demonstrate efficiency when we work on the right things, not doing more than needed, and not duplicating work.

GitLab Job Grade

Demonstrates Efficiency Competency by...

Knowledge Assessment

5

Develops an understanding of being a manager of 1 by taking responsibility for your own tasks and delivering on commitments. Brings up ideas for process improvements to 1:1s. Learns to write everything down as it is far more efficient to read a document at your convenience than to have to ask and explain.

Knowledge Assessment for Individual Contributors

6

Develops a deeper understanding of efficiency and actively identifies process inefficiencies within the team. Seeks out ways to be more effective in their role, while also starting to mentor others in ways to work efficiently.

7

Models a culture of efficiency within the team where people make good, timely decisions using available data and assessing multiple alternatives. Models using boring solutions for increasing the speed of innovation for our organization and product.

8

Takes ownership of own team process inefficiencies, implements cross team efforts in ensuring things are running smoothly. Implements a way of working in the team where team members first search for their own answers and, if an answer is not readily found or the answer is not clear, ask in public as we all should have a low level of shame.

Knowledge Assessment for People Leaders

9

Takes ownership of group level process inefficiencies and guides cross sub-departments in ensuring things are running smoothly. Fosters a culture in the sub-departments where you respect others' time and promote self-service and self-learning.

10

Drives the framework of frugality on a department level and owns departments efforts in ensuring things are running smoothly. Drives efficient resolution of highly complex or unusual business problems that impact the department / team. Holds their managers and peers accountable for upholding this value.

11

Develops the framework and strategy of frugality cross division resulting in efforts ensuring things are running smoothly. Develops leaders to action on division/department/team inefficiencies. Hold their management teams accountable for upholding this value.

12

Leads with efficiency across the company. Ensures efficient resource allocation decisions across the company. Leads across company strategy and policy improvements that move the business towards more efficiency. They hold their senior management and the e-group accountable for upholding this value.

EVP/CXO

Champions GitLab's strategy for efficiency internally and externally. Constantly looking for efficiency improvements cross company and holding other e-group members accountable for upholding efficiency too. They are comfortable leading through frugality and accepting of mistakes.

■ Diversity, Inclusion & Belonging {diversity-inclusion}

Diversity, inclusion and belonging are fundamental to the success of GitLab. We aim to make a significant impact in our efforts to foster an environment where everyone can thrive. We are designing a multidimensional approach to ensure that GitLab is a place where people from every background and circumstance feel like they belong and can contribute. We actively chose to build a culture that is inclusive and supports all team members equally in the process of achieving their professional goals. We work to make everyone feel welcome and to increase the participation of underrepresented groups in our community and company.

Bias towards asynchronous communication

Take initiative to operate asynchronously whenever possible. This shows care and consideration for those who may not be in the same time zone, are traveling outside of their usual time zone, or are structuring their day around pressing commitments at home or in their community.

This is demonstrated by communicating recordings of meetings, using GitLab Issues and Merge Requests rather than texts, calls, or Slack messages, and being sensitive to local holidays and vacation statuses. Encourage others to default to documentation rather than pressuring others to be online outside of their working hours.

Embracing uncomfortable ideas and conversations

Part of embracing diversity is a willingness to embrace often uncomfortable conversations and situations. This concept is also at the core of inclusion and helping to eliminate the problems that are faced by certain GitLab team members who may not be in the majority.

We believe that being willing to embrace discomfort is the path forward to a safe, balanced and inclusive work place for all. Challenge yourself, challenge your own pre-set notions and ideas about different cultures or things you don't understand. When we are willing to embrace being uncomfortable, we can focus on actually fixing the issues at hand rather than simply "appearing to care".

Understanding the impact of microaggressions

Microaggressions are much more than merely rude or insensitive comments. They can wear people down by slowly chipping away their sense of belonging/safety/inclusion over time. What is a microaggression?

> "The everyday slights, indignities, put downs and insults that people of color, women, LGBT populations or those who are marginalized experiences in their day-to-day interactions with people." - Derald W. Sue

At GitLab we believe that everyone is entitled to a safe working space where they can express who they are and participate in conversations without worry of being spoken to in a harmful way, given that we want to encourage everyone to be mindful of what is a microaggression and be mindful of their potential impact.

Seek diverse perspectives

We believe that team members seeking feedback from a diverse group of team members, inside and outside of their group or function, leads to better decisions and a greater sense of team member belonging. For more guidance on how we define Diversity, please refer to GitLab's definition of Diversity, Inclusion & Belonging. Feedback from a more heterogenous group often leads to better business outcomes as we incorporate diverse perspectives and uncover unconscious bias.

An example of this operating principle in action showcases the value of actively seeking diverse perspectives. The term "Brag Document" was used to describe when individuals documented their accomplishments. Documenting accomplishments is critical to team member development. However, team members had the psychological safety to raise the question of whether or not the title of the document made some feel uncomfortable. In an effort to seek a diverse perspective, a survey was conducted in one of the Team Member and Advocacy Resource Group (TMRG) channels. The poll results showed that 100% of those polled preferred a different title and the title was changed.

Make family feel welcome

One of the unique elements to an all-remote culture is the ability to visit a person's home while collaborating. If the tenor of the meeting allows, feel welcome to invite your family members or pets to drop by and greet your colleagues. Be mindful of language and use of profanity to encourage a family-friendly environment.

Shift working hours for a cause

Caregiving, outreach programs, and community service do not conveniently wait for regular business hours to conclude. If there's a cause or community effort taking place, feel welcome to work with your manager and shift your working hours to be available during a period where you'll have the greatest impact for good. For colleagues supporting others during these causes, document everything and strive to post recordings so it's easy for them to catch up.

Be a mentor

People feel more included when they're supported. To encourage this, and to support diversified learning across departments, consider GitLab's Internship for Learning program.

Culture fit is a bad excuse

We don't hire based on culture or select candidates because we'd like to have a drink with them. We hire and reward team members based on our shared values as detailed on this page. We want a values fit, not a culture fit.

We want cultural diversity instead of cultural conformity. Said differently: "culture add" > "culture fit" or "hire for culture contribution" since our mission is that everyone can contribute.

Religion and politics at work

We generally avoid discussing politics or religion in public forums because it is easy to alienate people that have a minority opinion. This doesn't mean we never discuss these topics. Because we value diversity, inclusion and belonging, and want all team members to feel welcome and contribute equally, we encourage free discussion of operational decisions that can move us toward being a more inclusive company.

There is sometimes a grey area where advocating for diversity and political activities may intersect. Team members should use discretion in grey area communications, because a culture of belonging requires us to be respectful of the broad spectrum of views within our work environment. What does this mean in practice? Please feel empowered to share information that highlights diversity, inclusion and belonging issues and how GitLab and GitLab team members can get involved. In line with our Code of Business Conduct and Ethics, avoid posting articles that reference specific political figures or parties.

While it is acceptable for individuals to bring up politics and religion in social contexts such as coffee chats and real-life meetups with other coworkers (with the goal to understand and not judge), always be aware of potential sensitivities, exercise your best judgment, and make sure you stay within the boundaries of our Code of Business Conduct and Ethics.

We're a global company where perspectives and local norms may differ from culture to culture. Diversity, inclusion and belonging is about broad inclusion at a worldwide level. If there is a question or

concern, please reach out to diversityinclusion@gitlab.com or [diversityinclusionandbelonging](#).

Quirkiness

Unexpected and unconventional things make life more interesting.

Celebrate and encourage quirky gifts, habits, behavior, and points of view. Open source is a great way to interact with interesting people. We try to hire people who think work is a great way to express themselves.

Building a safe community

Do not make jokes or unfriendly remarks about characteristics of the people who make up GitLab and how they identify.

Everyone has the right to feel safe when working for GitLab and/or as a part of the GitLab community.

We do not tolerate abuse, harassment, exclusion, discrimination, or retaliation by/of any community members, including our team members.

You can always refuse to deal with people who treat you badly and get out of situations that make you feel uncomfortable.

Unconscious bias

We recognize that unconscious bias is something that affects everyone and that the effect it has on us as humans and our company is large.

We are responsible for understanding our own implicit biases and helping others understand theirs. We are continuously working on getting better at this topic.

Inclusive benefits

We list our Parental Leave publicly so people don't have to ask during interviews.

Inclusive language & pronouns

Use inclusive language.

For example, prefer "Hi everybody" or "Hi people" to "Hi guys", and "they" instead of "he/she". While there are several good guides from folks like 18f, University of Calgary, and Buffer on using inclusive language, we don't keep an exhaustive list.

When new possibly non-inclusive words arise, we prefer to be proactive and look for an alternative.

If your goal is to be inclusive, it is more effective to make a small adjustment in the vocabulary when some people have a problem with it, rather than making a decision to not change it because some people don't think it is a problem.

And if you make a mistake (e.g. accidentally using the wrong pronoun or an outdated phrase), acknowledge it, apologize gracefully and move on; there is no need to dwell on it, and you can work to avoid making that mistake in the future.

Please also visit our [Gender and Sexual-orientation Identity Definitions and FAQ](#) page if you have questions around pronouns and other topics related to gender / sexual orientation.

Learn how to pronounce other people's names

We attach part of our identity to our names, and if it is mispronounced it can feel less inclusive.

If it happens repeatedly, you may be unintentionally sending a message to that person that you are not interested

in learning how to pronounce their name correctly. This applies to everyone you are in contact with:

team members, customers, candidates for jobs, and anyone else.

People whose name is repeatedly mispronounced might feel unimportant or self-conscious, and might not

speak up about it.

Other negative behaviors include giving a person a nickname without their permission, or actively avoiding using their name in sync calls.

It might be challenging to pronounce names from a different language or culture than your own, but with some effort, name pronunciation can be learned by anyone. Some ways to achieve this are:

- Ask the person for help in a private space: "I'm sorry, I don't think I am pronouncing your name correctly. Can you help me with the correct pronunciation?"
- Use the written and recorded pronunciation tools in Slack.
- Use online tools such as videos recorded on YouTube or NameShouts.
- Practice the pronunciation with a friend or team member who knows the correct pronunciation.
- Always avoid making jokes or comments about how it is difficult to pronounce their name.

Use of nicknames

Some people might choose to use a nickname, for example: "Bob" instead of "Robert".

As long as this is their choice this is perfectly acceptable.

We should avoid assigning a nickname to a person without their permission.

Slack pronunciation features

Slack has two features to help with this issue: the phonetic name pronunciation field and the ability to record your own name pronunciation audio clip. We encourage all team members to complete both of these. Update them by editing your profile.

Inclusive interviewing

This is documented on our page about interviewing.

Inclusive meetings

Be consciously inclusive in meetings by giving everyone present an opportunity to talk and present their points of view. This can be especially important in a remote setting.

With internal meetings, consider using an agenda document for questions. For example, with GitLab AMAs, every meeting has a numbered list that GitLab team members can add questions to. During the meeting, questions are answered in turn and discussions noted in the same document. Sometimes, these documents can have so much traffic (during the meeting) such that only a limited number of people can edit the document. In these situations, those who have questions should post on zoom chat and those who can edit the document should help copy the question over to the document. In addition, those who can edit the document should also post in zoom chat to see if anyone has any questions that they could help add to the document so that meeting attendees are more empowered to contribute to the conversation.

Customers are not used to working in this way. To promote inclusion with customers: ask participants for their goals; make sure during demos that you pause for question; leave time for discussion.

Inclusive and fair policy to regions with fewer employees

Being globally distributed has the benefit that someone can cover for you when you are off work. However, population density is not balanced across timezones. Policies should remain fair to those in less dense regions.

For example, the Asia Pacific region covers more timezones but has fewer team members. If we use an algorithm to assign tasks to those in later timezones, all American tasks would fall on the fewer Asia Pacific employees. This can damage belonging and inclusivity and should be avoided.

When planning an event, the organizer should cater for location density differences to maximize participation in all regions.

See Something, Say Something

As a globally-dispersed company, we have team members from many different backgrounds and cultures. That means it is important for each of us to use great judgment in being respectful and inclusive of our teammates. At the same time, we may sometimes not fully realize we have said or done something to offend someone. It is important that our teammates hold each other accountable and let them know if they have unintentionally or intentionally done something so they can learn and gain additional understanding of perspectives different from our own. It is also important that our teammates don't feel excluded or minimized by the words we use or the things we do. Thus, we all need to speak up when we see something that isn't respectful or inclusive.

Embracing Neurodiversity

Neurodiversity refers to variations in the human brain regarding learning, attention, sociability, mood, and other mental functions. There are various neurodevelopmental conditions, like autism, ADHD, dyslexia, dyscalculia, dyspraxia, cognitive impairment, schizophrenia, bipolarity, and other styles of neurodivergent functioning. While neurodivergent individuals often bring unique skills and abilities which can be harnessed for a competitive advantage in many fields (for example, cybersecurity), neurodivergent individuals are often discriminated against. Due to non-inclusive hiring practices, they sometimes have trouble making it through traditional hiring processes. Neurodiversity inclusion best practices benefit everyone, and at GitLab, everyone can contribute. The handbook, values, strategy, and interviewing processes must support the ability for everyone to thrive.

At GitLab we embrace Neurodiversity through adopting a variety of different work styles and communication styles, and we lean into transparency, asynchronous as a default working style, and pre-filled meeting agendas. These best practices become even more important when embracing neurodiversity. Providing multiple ways to consume information (written / video / audio) allows everyone to contribute independent of their preferred comprehension style. It is important to ask team members specifically what their preferred communication method is in order to provide them information in a format that is easily consumable for them.

Remember, brains work differently and always assume positive intent, even if someone behaves in an unexpected way. While it may be an unexpected behavior to you, it may not be unexpected to the individual exhibiting the behavior. That is the beauty and value of diversity, embracing differences and becoming stronger and better as a result.

We also recommend that all team members review the Reasonable Accommodation process. A Reasonable Accommodation for a team member could include noise-cancelling headphones, scheduling smaller group session zoom calls, providing very explicit and precise instructions and due-dates when given tasks, or providing a variety of supportive software tools.

The most important thing that managers can do is facilitate an environment in which all team members feel psychologically safe enough to make requests for what they need in order to do their job.

Family and friends first, work second

Long-lasting relationships are the rocks of life, and come before work. As someone said in our thanks channel after helping a family member for five days after a hurricane: "THANK YOU to GitLab for

providing a culture where "family first" is truly meant". Use the hashtag: FamilyAndFriends1st

Equity not just equality

Equity vs. Equality: What's the Difference?

> While the terms equity and equality may sound similar, the implementation of one versus the other can lead to dramatically different outcomes for marginalized people.

>

> Equality means each individual or group of people is given the same resources or opportunities. Equity recognizes that each person has different circumstances and allocates the exact resources and opportunities needed to reach an equal outcome.

Diversity, Inclusion & Belonging Competency

Competencies are the Single Source of Truth (SSoT) framework for things we need team members to learn.

We demonstrate diversity, inclusion and belongings when we foster an environment where everyone can thrive and ensuring that GitLab is a place where people from every background and circumstance feel like they belong and can contribute.

If you would like to improve your skills or expand your knowledge on topics relating to Diversity, Inclusion, & Belonging at GitLab, check out our resources:

- Being an Ally
- Being Inclusive
- Recognizing Bias

GitLab Job Grade

Demonstrates Diversi